

Shakespeare's fairy mischief

Magic provided William Shakespeare with an entertaining and thought-provoking way to communicate his ideas. In his romance comedy *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, written in 1595–1596, he uses magic to play with the theme of romantic love (as had many earlier, medieval romances): is it random madness or a type of magic? Is it ruled by otherworldly forces? Do supernatural beings have any more control over love than mortals?

The play parallels two sets of human lovers with Oberon and Titania (king and queen of the fairies) on their bumpy road to happiness. Central roles are played by a sprite known as Puck (architect of mischief) and a magic flower. Squeezed onto sleeping eyelids, the flower's juice makes both humans and fairies fall in love with whomever they see on first waking. Amusing chaos ensues, such as Titania becoming enraptured by a weaver called Bottom (see left), who has had an ass's head magically fixed over his own.

The fairy-filled woodland setting, where much of the action unfolds, may reflect folk and natural magic as well as the inherent wonder of the natural world. The shifting border between good and bad magic is evident in the character of Puck, who treads the line between being harmlessly naughty and slightly demonic. Sprites often had demonic associations in medieval times, and Puck makes such a connection, too, when he refers to the “damned spirits” of the night, in contrast with the fairies of daylight.

“But we are spirits
of another sort.”

OBERON IN SHAKESPEARE'S *A MIDSUMMER NIGHT'S DREAM*

